



I Didn't MEAN THAT!

SPEAKING TO THE MEDIA LIKE A PRO

Have you ever felt your kishkes turn as you watched a clip of a fellow shliach in the news? Perhaps he's speaking too quickly, pronouncing words incorrectly or has his comments taken out of context. You shake your head and inwardly cringe at his blatant blunder, even as you wonder what you would do if you were in the same situation.

Speaking with the media is an art. Although it may come more naturally to some, it is a skill which can be improved and perfected. You never know when your time will come, so it's worthwhile to study up and be prepared.

Get Ready

"Remember the Five P's — Prevent Poor Performance: Prepare Properly!" writes **Mrs. Rus Devorah Wallen** in "Shlichus Outreach Insights". This does not mean you should write every word of your speech and memorize it. You should, however, work out a logical sequence of ideas and carefully select words, metaphors and stories that will best convey those ideas.

"Don't worry that you'll sound too slick if you've done a lot of preparation. A good speech is like a good piece of silver; it won't wear out from too much polishing."

Once you know what you'll be saying, you may want to jot down a few notes on cards. "These cards are just to help you keep on track. Never read a whole speech straight from your cards! This is a sure way to lose your audience."

Know Your Crowd

"It is imperative to be mindful of the audience," says **Mrs. Baila Olidort**, Editor-in-Chief of Lubavitch News Service and Lubavitch.com. Throughout her years writing press releases and having them submitted to the Rebbe for editing, Mrs. Olidort received many horaos on the nuances of public relations.

"Be aware of how people will understand things, and word your statements appropriately. Some words have different connotation in different places. Some expressions may sound inspiring to you, but downright frightening to your baalei batim."

Often times a problem arises when a shliach translates or uses a word or

phrase that is common within Lubavitch circles, but may be very offensive to an outsider. Take an expression like "conquer the world." It's off putting. No one wants to be conquered. "Always weigh your words carefully; are they going to draw people in, or will they scare them away?" Says Mrs. Olidort.

Appreciating your audience also means knowing what will interest them. Stories about the growth of your Chabad House might bore some, while they might be intrigued by a tale of a Shliach assisting a Yid in middle of nowhere.

Know Before You Go

"If you are going to be interviewed, ask for the questions in advance," advises Mrs. Olidort. "If you can, it is best to send in written answers." If the interviewer prefers a phone interview, be prepared. Have your answers ready.

"Don't speak off the cuff. Don't be afraid of silence, and say the question needs more thoughtful consideration before a response."

You Don't Have to Say it

Rather than raise difficulties or ask questions that can't be answered, avoid troublesome issues. Our mission is to reach every Yid; for some, that may preclude discussing the situation in Eretz Yisroel, for example. You can't always say things as they are, just as surely as you cannot lie or fabricate ideals. Sometimes it's best to leave the issue alone. If discussing politics is likely to turn some away, leave your feelings about the presidential candidates left unspoken. It's not about hiding the truth, but rather about focusing on the mission, and not letting side details become major obstacles.

Stick to Your Guns. Respectfully.

It is best to be abundantly clear. Don't be vague. Don't mince words. Say what you want to say, and say it clearly. Yet while it is vital to be unyielding in your principles, do not antagonize or lose your crowd.

Rabbi Yudi Dukes, Director of JNet, relates the story of a Chabad woman who had a fierce debate with her JNet chavrusa regarding the morality and ethics of korbanos. Surprisingly, it was this argument which caused her chavrusa to send a donation to JNet stating, "Although I do not always agree with the views of my study partner, I am amazed at how she respects me and my views regardless." Says Rabbi Dukes,

המחנך והמדריך צריך לדעת כי לא רק פתגמים
מתאימים לענייני הוראותיו נוגעים בעיקר
תועלת החינוך וההדרכה, אלא גם אופן ביטוי
הפתגמים אם בנימוס ומתינות או בהתרגשות
וזלזול נוגע ביסודי תועלת החינוך וההדרכה.

—כללי חינוך והדרכה פרק ה'

“Stick to your beliefs, but keep the respect strong and steady.”

Speak Easy

There is a famous saying in the public speaking world: “Speak loudly so everyone will hear you; stand tall so everyone will see you; finish fast so everyone will like you.”

Brevity is vital to winning audiences, especially in the age of short YouTube clips and 140-character tweets.

When you talk, you want to sound smart but not so smart that people can’t relate to you. It may be enticing to loquaciously flaunt your verbose vocabulary. Resist the temptation. Keep it simple.

Good diction, pronunciation, vocabulary and usage are a must. If you’re not 100% sure that the word you’re using is correct, don’t use it until you look it up or ask someone. Some words sound similar but have a very different meaning.

Do your research before saying things like “anyways (anyway)”, “supposedly (supposedly)”, “owny (only)”, “for all intensive purposes” (for all intents and purposes), “suspicious occasion” (auspicious), “bought” or “brought”.

In his book “Basic Public Speaking”, **Douglas A. Parker, M.Ed.** recommends another way to make yourself better understood: slow down so people can understand you. “Pause. Allow yourself and your audience a little time to reflect and think. Don’t race through your presentation and leave your audience, as well as yourself, feeling out of breath.” This directive is particularly challenging for shlichim since they are usually very busy and have so much to say.

Rabbi Yosef Weinberg, who taught lessons in Tanya on the radio for many years, suggested the following to help make your words easier for the audience

It is best to be abundantly clear. Don’t be vague. Don’t mince words. Say what you want to say, and say it clearly...

to absorb: Tell the audience what you’re about to say. Give over the concept. Then explain what you just said. Or, in other words, say what you’re about to say; say it; then say it again.

Dr. Parker also suggests that you add humor whenever possible and appropriate. Even great chachomim like Rabah made use of this method to open the minds and hearts of their talmidim.

Be Accurate

“The Rebbe was averse to exaggerating,” says Mrs. Olidort. “He would cross out words like “enormous”, “explicitly” and other superlatives.

Everything had to be accurate. We couldn’t make any claims that couldn’t be substantiated.”

Listen to Yourself

Record yourself and hear how you sound. Remember to enunciate your words and speak clearly. You can even take a video of yourself and see what needs to be corrected.

“When you are presenting in front of an audience, you are performing as an actor is on stage,” explains Dr. Parker. “How you are being perceived is very important. Usually, the rule of thumb is to smile. But be solemn if your topic is se-

rious. Look pleasant, enthusiastic, confident, proud, but not arrogant.”

If you feel nervous, focus on breathing steadily and evenly. Speak slowly, enunciate clearly and show appropriate emotion and feeling relating to your topic. Vary the tone of your voice.

Be Memorable

You spend countless hours collaborating and innovating to put forth really good ideas. You should spend just as much energy ensuring they are delivered in a way that is impactful. Knowing how to do this can be your competitive edge on your community’s attention.

Create a rally cry. Your rally cry will be a small, repeatable phrase that can become the slogan and rallying cry of the masses trying to promote your idea. President Obama’s famous campaign slogan, “Yes We Can,” originated from a speech

during the primary elections. Parenthetically, this was the very same rally cry used by **Rabbi Moshe Bryski**, Shliach in Agoura Hills, CA years before. It’s short, inspiring and gets the point across.

Coordinate key phrases with the same language in your press materials. For presentations where the press is present, be sure to repeat critical messages verbatim from your press materials. Doing so ensures that the press will pick up the right sound bites (see box).

To ensure that the audience remembers your message, repeat the phrase more than once.

As shlichim of the Rebbe, we don’t only represent a movement, we represent the Rebbe. Every word and every appearance must be one that will make the Rebbe proud. Because no matter where we are or who is listening, the way we speak is how the Rebbe will be heard. 

THE MAGIC OF SOUND BITES

WHAT ARE SOUND BITES?

A sound bite is a short phrase that contains the essence of your message and encapsulates the concept in a memorable way. As the Friediker Rebbe says in Klolei Chinuch V’Hadracha:

ושתדל למצוא פתגמים מתאימים לההוראות ההם, ויביעם בביטויים יפים - למען אשר יחקקו בלב המוחנך והמודרך, ויעמדו לנגד עיניו גם בעת יצא מאת פני מחנכו ומדריכו...

Some examples from our leaders:

- ★ “Al tadin es chavercha ad shetaghiah limkomo.” —*Hillel in Pirkei Avos*
- ★ “Lichsheyafutzu maayonosecha chutzah.” —*Moshiach to the Baal Shem Tov*
- ★ “M’darf leben mit dem tzeit.” —*The Alter Rebbe*
- ★ “Lechatchilah ariber.” —*The Rebbe Maharash*
- ★ “Ker a velt heint.” —*The Rebbe*

Many of us are also familiar with famous sound bites from U.S. presidents (l’havdil):

- ★ “Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall.” —*Ronald Reagan*
- ★ “The only thing we have to fear is fear itself.” —*Franklin D. Roosevelt*
- ★ “Ask not what your country can do for you. Ask what you can do for your country.” —*John F. Kennedy*

VERBAL COLONS

In the Hagadah Shel Pesach, the Rebbe mentions that one of the differences between the telling of Yetzias Mitzrayim during the year and on the Seder night is that the story is told in question form. This idea helps to engage the audience, even if they are not actually responding.

Cypress Media Group suggests you use a “verbal colon” to draw attention to your main point and create a sound bite:

- ★ Consider this...
- ★ Remember this...
- ★ Case in point...
- ★ One final point...
- ★ Here’s the proof...
- ★ The most interesting aspect is this...
- ★ The main point to remember is this...
- ★ The biggest mistake we can make is this...

Make use of the “inserted question” to focus attention on your words. For example, instead of: “We have added many safety features to our building plan because we do not want even one injury on this project.”

Say: “We have added many safety features to our building plan. Why? Because we do not want even one injury on this project.”

CONTRASTS

According to Max Atkinson, Communications Researcher and Consultant, a contrast is another useful tool for creating interesting sound bites. There are different kinds of contrasts:

Contradictions: Not this, but that

“Not that avodah should be done with Emes, but Emes itself is the avodah.”

One of the most famous examples of this type of contrast from the “velt” is from Martin Luther King, Jr. when he said, “I have a dream that my four little children will one day live in a nation where they will not be judged by the color of their skin, but by the content of their character.”

Comparisons: Move this, than that

Take this very ordinary sounding sentence: “The various points I have outlined point to the need for us to do even better in the future.”

This can be transformed using a comparative sentence: “The important thing is not how good we are today, but how much better we need to be tomorrow.”

Opposites: Black or white

This contrast was used by Prime Minister Tony Blair when he said, “What the electorate gives, the electorate can take away.”

SPICE UP YOUR TALK

Brad Phillips, President of Phillips Media Relations, poses a number of tricks to add flavor to your sound bites:

Simile, metaphor or analogy

Yiddishkeit is filled with meshalim and comparisons that help bring out a point vividly.

“Be strong like a lion.”

“Stand before Hashem with awe and fear as though you are standing before a king.”

Witty

“Our choices right now are not between good and better; they’re between bad and worse.” (Alan Greenspan)

“She couldn’t get elected if two of her opponents died.”

Folksy

“When you hear somebody say, ‘This is not about money,’ it’s about money.”

Rhetorical

“Ad mosai?”

